order will continue in a successful manner.’5 In the same edition, Honecker’s biography sat in the top left corner of page two, it highlighted his ‘persistent, selfless commitment in the interest of the working people’.6

When all was said and done, Honecker never returned to an easy relationship with Ulbricht. His animosity was particularly visible when he renamed the ‘Walter Ulbricht Academy for State and Law’, and several ‘Walter Ulbricht’ factories and pulled two official Ulbricht biographies (described as the ‘greatest German Marxist-Leninist’) from bookstores.

Looking back from the perspective of three decades, Margot Honecker claimed (with a touch of embarrassment) that political differences did not detract from a ‘respectful’ relationship with Ulbricht, although, she said, ‘Walter did not always make things easy for comrades.’7 The ignominious parting for the two men – who had been each other’s fortune and misfortune – haunted the new First Secretary for the rest of his life. In a curious way, Erich deluded himself by insisting he was not the villain of the piece. In his version of events, Ulbricht voluntarily resigned, ‘and we for our part suggested that he should remain the chairman of the State Council and honorary chairman of the party. This was a prime example of how one respects older comrades who have attained great achievements.’8